



The Rocky Mountains

A region of sublime natural beauty comprising the central part of one of the greatest mountain belts on Earth, the Western Cordillera of North America



The Rocky Mountains, or Rockies, extend for almost 3,000 miles (4,800 km), running southward from the northern part of British Columbia in Canada and passing through parts of six U.S. states, from Montana to New Mexico. Located within the range is North America's Continental Divide: to the west of this divide, rivers flow into the Pacific, and to the east they flow into the Atlantic or Arctic Oceans. The highest peak in the Rockies is Mount Elbert in Colorado, at 14,440 ft (4,401 m).

Shaping the Rockies

The Rockies mainly formed in stages over the last 80 million years and have a geologically complex history. The range contains many examples of folding and thrust faulting (see panel, left), for example, in the Canadian Rockies and Montana. The Rockies also include areas, such as Yellowstone National Park (see pp.30–33), that have been extensively affected by volcanic activity, as well as regions impacted by glaciation during various ice ages.

A number of the peaks are covered in coniferous forests, with alpine tundra above the treeline. Many animals inhabit the Rocky Mountains, including elk,

moose, mountain goats and sheep, bears, wolverines, and bald eagles. With its stunning scenery, this range is a popular leisure-time destination, especially for activities such as camping, hiking, fishing, and mountain biking.

▽ YOUNG AND RUGGED

Pushed up in the past 13 million years, the Teton Range in Wyoming is one of the youngest parts of the Rockies. It features several peaks exceeding 12,100 ft (3,700 m) in height.

